

DESK 42 DESIGN CONTRACT AMENDMENT

v1.1 - CLAIM DISPOSITIONS AND CONFIRMATION

This amendment is authoritative and overrides the conflicting claim-resolution language in sections 8 and 36 of GDD v1.0.

Claims do not have objectively correct, incorrect, humane, or bureaucratic dispositions. The player chooses APPROVE, DENY, or LIQUIFY. The game reports what happened and what it cost, and never grades the disposition.

Corporate rewards and the COMPLIANCE STREAK communicate institutional preference, not moral truth.

All claim feedback derives from the applied disposition result after mutation, clamping, and modifiers. Receipts report actual resource changes. Card failures, claim receipts, cascade steps, and expense results are semantic confirmation and may not be discarded as optional feedback.

Personal obligations are generated once at shift start, remain visible while the player can still make economic choices, survive resume unchanged, and are applied once at clock-out.

AUTHORITATIVE

DESK 42

ANOMALOUS CLAIMS

Complete Game Design Document
Version 1.0

Systemic Desk Simulator / Bureaucratic Dark Comedy / Rogue-lite

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PART I: FOUNDATION

1. Project Overview & Vision

Project Title: Desk 42: Anomalous Claims

Genre: Systemic Desk Simulator / Bureaucratic Dark Comedy / Rogue-lite

Core Aesthetic: Retro-Futuristic Corporate Surrealism

Elevator Pitch: You are a claims investigator at a bureaucratic agency that processes anomalous insurance claims filed by aliens, eldritch entities, and interdimensional beings. Your desk is your battlefield. Your punch-card machine is your weapon. Your sanity is your health bar. Survive your shift. Clock out. Come back tomorrow.

1.1 Design Thesis

Desk 42 exists to prove that complex systemic game architecture — behaviour trees, state machines, adaptive AI, emergent narrative — can be recontextualized from tactical combat into bureaucratic dark comedy without losing mechanical depth. The same modular scripts that drive a tactical siege simulator can power a desk-bound roguelite where filing paperwork is as strategically rich as commanding an army.

The game operates on a single core principle: **the mundane containing the impossible**. Every mechanic, visual element, audio cue, and narrative beat exists in the gap between banal office work and cosmic horror. The comedy and the dread both emerge from that gap.

1.2 Target Audience

Players who love Balatro, Inscryption, Papers Please, Hades, and Slay the Spire. People who appreciate dark humour, systemic depth, and games that reward curiosity. The aesthetic targets fans of Severance, Control, Men in Black, and Loki's TVA. Age range: 18-35. Core market: roguelite enthusiasts on Steam PC.

1.3 Unique Selling Points

The Desk Is the Game. Unlike traditional roguelites where the UI is a window into the game world, in Desk 42 the UI IS the game world. Your desk, your monitor, your forms, your Post-it notes — they are all interactive, destructible, corruptible gameplay surfaces.

Behaviour Tree Injection. Players physically alter the AI's decision-making in real-time by slamming punch cards into a pneumatic machine. No other roguelite gives the player direct, tactile control over the enemy's behaviour tree.

Bureaucratic Dark Comedy as a Genre. Not satire layered on top of gameplay, but comedy that emerges FROM the systems. The game generates its own jokes based on player behaviour, creating shareable moments that feel organic rather than scripted.

Moral Injury as a Mechanic. Soul integrity isn't just a flavour stat — it physically changes the UI, the audio landscape, the narrator's reliability, and the available endings. Being a good person makes the game mechanically harder.

2. Core Aesthetic: Retro-Futuristic Corporate Surrealism

Desk 42's visual and tonal identity blends four distinct aesthetic traditions into a subgenre that no existing game occupies.

2.1 The Grounding Layer: Severance + Control

The architectural bones of the world. Mid-century modernism layered with brutalist and retro-futuristic undertones. Temporal ambiguity — the office exists in non-time, feeling simultaneously like the 1960s, the 1980s, and some undefined future. Design as psychological control: symmetrical layouts, sterile corridors, controlled lighting, minimal ornamentation. The horror comes from architectural banality — this is a place you have actually worked.

2.2 The Technological Philosophy: TVA (Loki) + Men in Black

Analog technology that never stopped evolving. Digital technology simply never existed in this world — analogue systems became impossibly sophisticated instead. The punch-card machine is made of chrome and Bakelite but processes reality-altering operations. CRT monitors display data no cathode ray should be capable of rendering. The technology is retro not as nostalgia but as institutional inertia — nobody filed the requisition form for an upgrade.

2.3 The Environmental Personality: Rocko's Modern Life

The office itself is alive, sardonic, and slightly hostile. This influence manifests not in character design but in environmental behaviour. Filing cabinets are slightly too tall. Corridors curve when they should not. The clock runs at the wrong speed. As sanity drops, parallel lines stop being parallel, right angles become obtuse, fluorescent fixtures tilt, the ceiling gets closer. The mundane architecture of Severance with Rocko's wonky, crooked geometry creeping in at the edges.

2.4 The Tonal Precedent: Men in Black + Brazil + Hitchhiker's Guide

Deadpan delivery of impossible information. The comedy is never acknowledged by the world — characters treat interdimensional insurance fraud with the same bored professionalism as a real claims adjuster. Absurdism expressed through bureaucratic language: "the client experienced an involuntary spatial relocation" rather than "the client was teleported." Corporate speak as both comedy and horror.

3. Art Direction & Visual Identity

3.1 Colour Palette

Zone	Primary	Secondary	Function
Office (Healthy)	Deep green, sterile white	Dusty blue	Severance-clean baseline
Office (Degraded)	Yellowed white, rust orange	Sickly green	Moral Injury visual decay
UI Elements	Cream, warm grey	Muted orange accents	Retro-futuristic readability
Anomalous Events	Saturated teal, electric blue	Glitch magenta	Cosmic intrusion on mundane
Meta-Hub	Warm wood tones, brass	Amber lamp light	Safety / respite contrast

3.2 Typography

All in-game text uses period-appropriate typefaces: Futura, Helvetica, and Eurostile rendered on CRT-style displays with subtle scan lines. Forms and memos use monospaced typewriter fonts (Courier / American Typewriter). The Daily Memo header uses a 1960s corporate masthead style. As Moral Injury increases, typefaces degrade — kerning loosens, baselines drift, characters occasionally swap.

3.3 Environmental Distortion Scale

Sanity Level	Visual State	Audio State
100-75%	Clean geometry, warm lighting, correct proportions	Ambient muzak, gentle keyboard clicks, distant coffee brewing
74-50%	Fluorescents flicker subtly, shadows deepen, slight asymmetry	High-pitched hums, clock ticks louder, phone rings shriller
49-25%	Walls lean inward, ceiling lowers, colours shift toward yellow	Noise floor, heavy breathing, heartbeat underlay, atonal jazz
24-1%	Full Rocko-style distortion: crooked geometry, impossible angles, doors distorted, speck	Triangles, doors, distorted speech, hostile environmental audio
0% (Fugue)	Desaturation, aggressive flicker, UI elements physically tilted	Total silence except slow breathing

PART II: CORE SYSTEMS

4. The Bureaucratic State Machine (BSM)

Every Client and Office Tool operates on a Bureaucratic State Machine. Clients do not simply attack — they transition through bureaucratic moods based on your UI interactions, the game's environmental state, your accumulated reputation, and the encounter's history.

4.1 Client States (9 States)

State	Trigger	Behaviour	Dark Humour Output
PENDING	Default / Reset	Calm, waiting for file to open	"Please take a number."
AGITATED	Loud typing, ignoring eye contact	Faster key behaviour tree ticks, aggressive posture	Desk items rattle; coffee ripples
LITIGIOUS	HR violations, repeated hostility	Files complaint, blocks REASSIGN slot	"With legal will I deal about this."
COOPERATIVE	Caffeine sharing, empathy routing	Reveals hidden traits without NDA	Awkward small talk attempts
SUSPICIOUS	Contradictions in paperwork	Repeat Offender flag, asks cooperation card	Squints at your Post-it notes
RESIGNED	Overwhelming bureaucratic pressure	Complies with everything, reveals nothing	Thousand-yard stare, heavy sighs
PARANOID	High Exposure, caught lying	Counter-complaints, blocks card slots	Covertly reads your Post-its
DISSOCIATING	Extreme cascading stress	Stops responding to inputs for short periods	Stares through you at the wall
SMUG	Client reaches dominant encounter position	Stops monologues, reveals info	Leans back (traps feet on desk)

4.2 Conditional State Transitions

The same player action produces different state transitions depending on contextual variables: the client's species, their counter-traits from the Repeat Offender Database, the current Office Temperature state, the player's Moral Injury level, active faction alignments, and whether this is a first visit or a return. A single THREATEN card can produce five or more different state transitions depending on world state. This conditional branching is the primary engine of per-run variety.

4.3 Behaviour Tree Mutations (Within-Encounter Adaptation)

Every time a player injects a state via punch card, there is a probability the client's behaviour tree adapts in real-time. A PENDING_REVIEW injection that works once may be blocked by a "Pre-Filed Exemption" node the second time. This prevents memorisation of optimal card sequences and ensures that even within a single claim, the player must read and adapt to the client's evolving behaviour.

4.4 Behaviour Tree Tells

Before transitioning states, clients broadcast subtle signals — animation tics, audio cues, dialogue cadence shifts. A client approaching LITIGIOUS straightens their papers. A client approaching PARANOID glances at the door. Repeat Offenders have different, harder-to-read tells than first-timers. Learning to read tells is a long-term mastery skill that improves across dozens of runs.

4.5 Environmental State: The Office Temperature

State	Condition	Effect
PEAK_EFFICIENCY	Bright lights, fast UI response	High Impatience drain, but faster processing
LUNCH_BREAK	Low pressure, UI dials recover	Clients become unpredictable
SYSTEM_CRASH	Fugue State trigger	UI flickers, whispers become screams, reboot puzzle required

5. The Red Tape Engine (Behaviour Tree Injection)

Design DNA: Baba Is You — Rules are objects that can be manipulated at runtime.

The Red Tape Engine is the core interaction verb of Desk 42. The player physically slams punch cards into a loud, clunky pneumatic machine. Each card instantiates a new subtree at the top of the client's Behaviour Tree, forcing immediate tactical changes.

5.1 The State Injection Pattern

A StateInjector class listens for OnCardSlammed events. When a card is slammed, it pushes a new State onto the Client's StateStack. The StateStack always executes the top state. A PENDING_REVIEW state has a Duration of 10 seconds during which the Client's normal Behaviour Tree is completely paused. The client is forced to comply with the injected state — filling out a requisition form, pausing an acid attack, or reorganising their complaint — before their original behaviour resumes.

5.2 Interaction Design

The tactile satisfaction is critical. The THUNK of the machine, the mechanical grinding as the card processes, the visual feedback of the client's behaviour visibly changing — this is the game's most important feedback loop. The card physically slides into the machine, a gear mechanism visibly rotates, and the output is a behaviour change that the player can see and hear immediately.

6. The Punch-Card Synergy System

Design DNA: Balatro + Slay the Spire — Layered synergy systems where every layer feeds every other layer.

Players build a deck of Punch Cards that interact in emergent ways with Office Supplies (relics), Departmental Stamps (consumables), Anomaly Classification Tags, Desk Layout Zones, and the Scoring Cascade. The synergy system is designed so that broken combinations are not bugs — they are the reward.

6.1 Office Supplies (Run-Specific Relics)

Supply	Effect	Synergy Potential
The Red Pen	Increases THREATEN punch card damage	Combo with Auditor archetype for control builds
The Ergonomic Chair	Reduces Sanity drain from Don't Look Up zone	Enables extended observation strategies
The Bottomless Coffee Mug	Slows Impatience timer, increases UI Jitter	Risk-reward: more time but less precision
The Paperclip	Allows LEGAL type cards to be played twice	Enables Infinite Loophole build
The Stale Donut	High Moral Injury + Donut = Fugue State where cards cost 50% more	Classics costs synergy target randomly

6.2 Emergent Synergy Example: The Infinite Loophole

Combining the RECURSIVE_FILING card with the Paperclip supply allows a LEGAL type card to be played twice. If the doubled card is PENDING_REVIEW, the client is locked in paperwork for 20 seconds instead of 10. During that window, the player can stack additional injections. This is not a scripted combo — it emerges from the intersection of card type, supply effect, and state duration.

7. NDAs & Sensory Deprivation

Design DNA: Inscryption + Iron Lung — Physical screen constraints as claustrophobic gameplay.

The player can stamp ANALYSE on a case file to reveal a client's hidden procedural trait. However, doing so forces the player to sign a Non-Disclosure Agreement. A physical piece of paper prints out and permanently covers a corner of the screen, cluttering the desk and creating systemic sensory deprivation. Each NDA reduces the player's visible workspace. At high NDA counts, critical UI elements (Willpower gauge, Impatience timer, card hand) are partially or fully obscured. The player must choose between information (knowing the client's weakness) and visibility (being able to see their own tools).

8. HR Violations & Moral Injury

Design DNA: Papers Please — Compassion has a literal price tag.

Moral Injury measures soul integrity rather than sanity. Unethical punch-card combinations (framing a client for tax fraud, signing excessive NDAs, prioritising efficiency over empathy) increase Moral Injury. High Moral Injury triggers Desensitisation: sanity drain is reduced (the investigator stops caring), but the UI becomes passive-aggressive, refusing to yield positive Virtues during stress rolls. The Moral Ledger tracks every ethical choice. Every claim has a "correct" bureaucratic resolution and a "humane" resolution. Processing correctly earns full Corporate Credits but costs Soul Integrity. Processing humanely preserves soul but costs credits and risks citations. The player has personal expenses each shift (rent, medication, break room coffee fund). Unmet expenses cause desk deterioration — fewer card draws, slower processing, dimmer lighting.

9. The Repeat Offender Database (Adaptive Rivalry)

Design DNA: The Dark Queen of Mortholme — Procedurally generated counter-traits.

The game logs player tactics into a persistent Priority Matrix. If a player defeats a client variant using the THREATEN AUDIT block too often, the database procedurally generates a counter-trait for that variant's next visit. The client returns with "Retained Counsel" (blocking THREATEN cards), "Loud Chewer" (draining Focus), or "Filed First" (starting in LITIGIOUS state). The database persists across runs, creating an ever-evolving adversarial relationship between player and game.

10. The Rumor Mill Event Bus

A global Event Bus ensures one action triggers a chain reaction across all systems. When you frame a client for tax fraud: the event `OnUnethicalAction.Invoke(TaxFraud)` fires. A memo appears from a colleague congratulating your "ruthless efficiency." Future clients of that species arrive in the LITIGIOUS state by default. Your Moral Injury increases. The faction standings shift. The Daily Memo next shift references the incident. The Rumor Mill is the connective tissue between every system in the game — it ensures that nothing happens in isolation.

10.1 Rumor Mill as Dark Humour Engine

Memos are generated from game state, not hand-written. If you use THREATEN cards aggressively: "NOTICE: Due to recent HR feedback, all threatening gestures must now be submitted in triplicate. Form 11-C (Intimidation Request) is available from Filing." If you sign too many NDAs: "REMINDER: Employees are reminded that they are not permitted to discuss, reference, acknowledge, or think about the existence of [REDACTED]. Failure to comply will result in [REDACTED]." If a client destroyed your desk last shift: "FACILITIES UPDATE: Desk replacement request #4,847 has been approved. Expected delivery: 6-8 business weeks. A cardboard box has been provided."

11. The Post-it Memory System

Instead of a quest log, narrative progress is tracked via Post-it Notes. When a client mentions a secret, the investigator scribbles it on a Post-it and sticks it to the monitor. These are physical UI objects — moveable, losable, corruptible. If the monitor glass cracks (UI Decay), Post-its can be "lost," forcing the player to physically remember their narrative progress or protect their notes. In the Meta-Hub, Post-its are arranged on a Conspiracy Board. Connecting correct fragments unlocks the path to The Great Audit.

12. Binaural Corporate Stress (Audio UI)

Design DNA: Hellblade + Ape Out — Spatial audio as HUD replacement and procedural soundtrack.

3D Spatial Audio and HRTF separate internal mental sounds from external office sounds. A jammed punch card sounds like a dying printer in the right ear. A low Protocol gauge triggers a monotone HR voice whispering corporate wellness advice into the left ear. The supervisor's footsteps are spatially positioned — approaching from a specific direction with a rhythm that indicates mood. No visual indicator accompanies audio threats — sound is the only warning for off-screen dangers.

PART III: GAME MODES

13. Mode 1: The 9-to-5 (Core Campaign)

Design DNA: FTL / IXION + Against the Storm

A "Run" represents a single work shift. The player is clocked in at their desk processing a procedural queue of Clients. After each claim, the player chooses their next task from a Job Board (High Risk/High Reward Audit vs. Low Risk/Low Reward Filing). The mode is governed by The Tide AI Storyteller, which monitors Cognitive Budget and the Unpaid Overtime (Impatience) timer. Over-performance triggers Office Hazards (Printer Jam = UI lockout, Mandatory Meeting = timer acceleration). Under-performance triggers mercy windows (mandated union breaks).

14. Mode 2: The Internal Audit (Meta-Hub / Puzzle Mode)

Design DNA: Disco Elysium — UI elements as sub-personalities.

Between runs, the player returns to the Internal Audit hub. The client leaves, and the player must do paperwork on themselves. Using the Internal Family Systems concept, the player interacts with their own UI dials (Caffeine, Protocol, Plausible Deniability) as distinct sub-personalities via internal dialogue. Logic puzzles repair cracked UI glass, clear physical red tape, and upgrade the investigator through literal mechanical maintenance on their own mind. Corporate Credits earned in runs are spent on permanent Employee Benefits.

14.1 The Employee Handbook (Skill Tree)

Benefit	Effect
Health Insurance	Permanently increases Max Sanity
Seniority	Unlocks higher-tier Punch Cards in the procedural pool
Union Membership	Grants one Mercy Window (run save) per shift
Dual Monitors	Increases Focus Zone (visible desk area)
Pneumatic Tube Upgrade	Increases Punch-Card Machine action speed
Soundproofing	Reduces Binaural Whisper volume, easier to ignore

15. Mode 3: Unpaid Overtime (Hardcore / Death State)

Design DNA: Look Outside + Dissociative Mechanics

When Cognitive Budget hits zero, you do not die — you dissociate. The environment desaturates, fluorescent lights aggressively flicker, audio heavily muffles. This is the Fugue State: UI dials may ignore your toggles or act on irrational behaviours. The player must sacrifice case progress to claw back to sanity and clock out. This replaces the traditional Game Over screen with a desperate survival phase that is itself mechanically engaging.

16. Mode 4: The Daily Brief (Seeded Daily Challenge)

Every 24 hours, a globally seeded claim queue drops for all players. Identical cases, identical punch-card offerings, identical shop inventory. Players compete for highest Efficiency Rating on a public leaderboard. Runs last approximately 15 minutes. Weekly rotating modifiers: Redaction Monday (claim text partially obscured), Merger Friday (two departments' rules apply simultaneously). The leaderboard is the company's internal ranking board.

17. Mode 5: Regulatory Compliance Vows (Modular Difficulty)

Design DNA: Hades 2 Oath of the Unseen

Players activate specific bureaucratic penalties from a Compliance Board before each shift. Each Vow has 3 ranks. Combined Compliance Score gates exclusive rewards (Audit Points for cosmetics and exclusive skill tree branches). Maximum Compliance Score should be nearly impossible, creating community prestige.

Vow	Rank 1	Rank 2	Rank 3
Budget Cuts	20% fewer supply offerings	40% fewer	60% fewer
Hiring Freeze	No new cards after Act 2	After Act 1	Starting deck only
Mandatory Overtime	Timer 15% faster	30% faster	50% faster
Open Door Policy	2 clients simultaneous	3 clients	4 clients
Regulatory Overhaul	1 new rule per ante	2 per ante	3 per ante
Whistleblower Hotline	Rumor Mill 25% more frequent	50%	100%

18. Mode 6: Branch Office Transfer (Adventure / Remix)

Self-contained mini-campaigns (3-5 shifts each) set in different departments with unique rules, restricted tools, and bespoke objectives. Each completed adventure unlocks a unique office supply relic for the main campaign.

Department	Unique Rules	Core Mechanic Change
Occult Containment	Only supernatural claims, containment cards only	Defensive play, no standard filing

The Mailroom	Sorting-based gameplay, spatial logistics	Physical item management replaces form processing
Legal Department	Argument-based combat, deposition mechanics	Objection cards, precedent system
The Call Center	Audio-only claims, no visual documents	Pure listening-based deduction

19. Mode 7: The Hell Rush (Async Competitive Multiplayer)

Eight bureaucrats receive identical claim queues simultaneously with a real-time timer per claim. Speed-focused builds become viable. Winner determined by highest efficiency score. Completing 5 Hell Rushes earns a cosmetic Desk Frame visible to other players. The corporate rat race made literal.

20. Mode 8: Custom Audits (Player-Created Challenges)

Players design custom rule sets from 35+ mutators (claim types, difficulty modifiers, deck restrictions, timer settings, specific Compliance Vows), then share via deeplink/code. Each Custom Audit generates its own leaderboard. A weekly Featured Audit spotlights community designs. Creating bureaucratic rules for others to suffer through is the ultimate middle-management fantasy.

21. Mode 9: Hurry Mode (Compressed Session Toggle)

A toggle that doubles clock speed, halving session time to approximately 12 minutes. Claim queues compressed, rewards slightly increased. Compatible with all other modes as a stackable modifier. Addresses the primary barrier to roguelite engagement: "I don't have time." The frantic energy of "I have a meeting in 15 minutes."

PART IV: PUNCH-CARD ARCHETYPES

22. Archetype Overview & Design Philosophy

Each archetype answers "how do I win?" in a fundamentally different way. 11 archetypes combined with 8 Compliance Vow tiers produce 88 unique victory conditions — the completion matrix that drives long-tail engagement. Each archetype introduces a unique resource, targets a different existing system, and creates a distinct decision space.

23. The Core Three

The Auditor (Control)

Unique Resource: Standard card draw

Focuses on PENDING_REVIEW and LEGAL_HOLD cards to stall the client. Control-oriented gameplay that locks down encounters through bureaucratic procedure. Win condition: never let the client act freely.

The Gaslighter (Psychological)

Unique Resource: Doubt tokens

Uses REDACT and FORGET cards to manipulate the client's memory and perception. Erases evidence, rewrites complaint history, makes clients doubt their own claims. Win condition: the client withdraws their complaint voluntarily.

The Bureaucrat (Efficiency)

Unique Resource: Efficiency meter

Focuses on EXPEDITE and AUTO_FILE cards to process claims faster. Speed-based gameplay that races the Impatience timer rather than fighting it. Win condition: process everything before anything goes wrong.

24. The Systems Trio

The Intern (Chaos & Sacrifice)

Unique Resource: Coffee Run tokens

Temp Cards are cheap and single-use but have outsized effects. Coffee Run tokens fuel card draw and replay. The First Day passive grants bonus effects for the first play of each card type. Extremely high variance — amazing ceiling, inconsistent floor.

The IT Person (Systems Exploitation)

Unique Resource: Debug tokens

Debug Tokens placed directly onto behaviour tree nodes to modify, reroute, or disable AI branches. Interacts with the Red Tape Engine directly rather than through clients. Stack Overflow triggers at 5+ tokens — system crash, all tokens removed, client enters AGITATED.

The Whistleblower (Escalating Exposure)

Unique Resource: Exposure + Heat

Exposure is both power source and danger meter. At thresholds (3/6/9), powerful abilities unlock alongside Corporate Retaliation events. The only archetype that gains soul integrity from core gameplay. Loses soul integrity from inaction.

25. The Corporate Trio

The HR Rep (Weaponised Compliance)

Unique Resource: Policy Cards + Violation tokens

Policy Cards are persistent modifiers restricting both player and clients. Violations accumulate: warning, write-up, final notice, TERMINATION (instantly resolves a claim, maximum soul damage). Most powerful tools are most morally corrosive.

The Middle Manager (Delegation & Blame)

Unique Resource: Direct Reports + Action Items + Blame tokens

Never processes claims directly — everything delegated to Direct Reports or queued as Action Items. Blame Tokens redirect consequences. If all Reports burn out, consequences cascade onto you multiplied.

The Consultant (Expensive Ephemeral Power)

Unique Resource: Billable Hours + Jargon

Billable Hours start high, decrease every turn. Cards get weaker as Hours deplete. Framework Cards are one-use-per-run mega-effects. At 0 Hours, all Consultant cards removed from deck. Glass cannon with a hard timer.

26. The Specialist Duo

The Union Rep (Solidarity Through Diversity)

Unique Resource: Solidarity (scales with archetype diversity)

Gets stronger the more different archetypes are represented in deck. Picket Line prevents client escalation. Grievance Cards debuff the encounter itself. The best secondary archetype — low solo power, extremely high hybrid synergy.

The Archivist (Information Permanence)

Unique Resource: The Archive + Institutional Memory

Cards filed into a persistent Archive — removed from draw but retrievable at will. Directly interacts with Post-it Memory System. Institutional Memory passively strengthens all Archivist cards per resolved claim. Gets permanently stronger from the Repeat Offender Database.

PART V: SYNERGY ARCHITECTURE

27. Synergy Design Philosophy

Five interacting synergy layers where every layer feeds every other. Playing cards generates stamps, stamps modify claims, claims trigger tags, tags affect zones, zones multiply scores. The key principle: relics do not just buff — they redefine which cards are good.

28. Departmental Stamps

Five stamp types (Filing, Legal, Occult, Accounting, Management). Single-use consumables that modify claims during processing. Stamps interact with punch cards: a Bureaucrat card on a Filing-Stamped claim gets double efficiency. Stamps shift faction standing, creating a three-way synergy axis: stamp choice x punch card x faction reputation.

28. Anomaly Classification Tags

Every claim carries 1-3 classification tags from a pool of approximately 15: TEMPORAL, SPATIAL, BIOLOGICAL, PSYCHIC, FINANCIAL, MEMETIC, BUREAUCRATIC, DIVINE, INFERNAL, DIMENSIONAL, etc. Punch cards and office supplies have tag affinities. Three matching tags trigger a Classification Cascade (bonus event). Three conflicting tags trigger Anomalous Interference. This creates a discoverable interaction space of over 150 tag combinations.

29. Regulatory Tiers

Once per ante, players purchase a Regulation from the Compliance Shop. Regulations permanently modify meta-rules for the rest of the run. Tier-2 Regulations upgrade existing ones. This creates a permanent investment layer where early economy decisions compound across the entire run.

29. Desk Layout Zones

The physical desk has designated zones: Inbox, Processing Area, Outbox, Personal Space, Dead Zone. Office supplies placed in different zones gain different effects. The same Stapler in the Processing Area fast-tracks paperwork; in the Dead Zone, it becomes a weapon. Zone capacity is limited, forcing spatial optimisation.

30. The Scoring Cascade

Claim resolution runs through a multiplicative evaluation cascade: base resolution (additive) -> punch card bonuses (additive) -> office supply bonuses (multiplicative) -> stamp effects (conditional multipliers) -> tag matches (bonus chips) -> zone bonuses (positional multipliers) -> faction rewards (scaling multipliers). Order of operations matters — a x2 multiplier applied after all additive bonuses is exponentially more valuable than one applied first.

PART VI: EXPANDED GAMEPLAY SYSTEMS

31. Cross-Claim Deduction System

Design DNA: Obra Dinn

Claims contain details that only make sense when cross-referenced with other claims. Deductions are confirmed in batches of three, preventing brute-force guessing. Successfully linked clusters unlock hidden case files, bonus rewards, and narrative revelations. Players flag connections on the Conspiracy Board using Post-it notes.

32. The Claim Queue Grid (Spatial Adjacency)

Design DNA: Luck Be a Landlord

Claims arrive in a 3x3 grid. Adjacent claim types trigger bonuses: a paranormal claim next to a financial claim generates a "Money Laundering Through Dimensions" bonus. Over 40 adjacency pairs create a discovery space explored across dozens of runs. Office supplies modify grid rules.

33. Departmental Factions

Design DNA: Against the Storm

Five departments (Filing, Legal, Occult Containment, Accounting, Management) with competing priorities. At reputation thresholds (3/6/9), factions offer powerful rewards. Raising one faction inevitably lowers another. Inter-departmental politics as core comedy and strategic depth.

34. Escalating Regulations

Design DNA: Papers Please

Each ante/day adds new verification requirements. Day 1: name and claim type. Day 5: cross-department authorisation stamps. Day 10: metaphysical resonance readings. The physical desk space does not grow, creating information overload through spatial constraint.

35. Office Supply Evolution

Design DNA: Vampire Survivors

Office supplies evolve when paired with specific punch cards at threshold counts. Stapler + Red Tape cards (3 played) becomes Auto-Stapler. Union evolutions require two supplies combined, consuming both slots for one powerful tool. Evolution creates build commitment.

36. The Moral Ledger

Design DNA: Papers Please

Every claim has a correct bureaucratic resolution and a humane resolution. Personal expenses each shift (rent, medication, coffee fund) must be met. Unmet expenses cause desk deterioration. Being a good person literally makes the game harder. The central horror of bureaucracy.

PART VII: UI/UX AS GAMEPLAY

37. CorpOS (Corporate Desktop Simulation)

The entire game runs within a simulated corporate operating system. Email client (memos, chain emails with conspiracy clues, spam from entities). Claims database (Her Story-style keyword search, limited to 5 results per search). Internal messenger (coworkers share Rumor Mill events in real-time). Corporate intranet (browsable department pages, employee profiles, suspicious wellness section). File manager (claim files, Post-its, evidence — corruptible by anomalous events).

38. Anomalous Form Corruption

During encounters, the claim form fights back. Text rearranges mid-sentence. Form fields swap. Checkboxes multiply then disappear. The APPROVED stamp drifts across the screen. Drop-down menus contain impossible options. At higher tiers, corruption spreads to the desk — Post-its rewrite themselves, the email client sends unsolicited messages. Specific anomalies have signature corruption patterns that become diagnostic tools.

39. Stand Up From the Desk (Office Exploration)

At any point, the player can stand up and explore the office in first-person. Locked filing cabinets opened via form-processing logic puzzles. Break room with physical Conspiracy Board. Coworker desks with visible screen clues. Supply closet as relic shop. The office changes between shifts. Key narrative revelations only accessible by standing up.

40. The Reflection (Diegetic Monitor Mirror)

The monitor subtly reflects the player character's face. As soul integrity decreases, the reflection changes: bags under eyes, flattened expression, dead eyes. At critical thresholds, the reflection acts independently — looking away, smiling at denials. At zero soul integrity, the reflection replaces you, auto-processing claims with maximum efficiency and zero compassion.

41. Dual-Use Desk Objects

Every desk object has an official function and a secret function. Stapler: fastens documents (batch processing) OR fires staples at entities. Desk lamp: illuminates hidden text OR functions as a containment beam. Coffee mug: provides buffs OR eavesdrops on adjacent offices when empty. Paper shredder: destroys documents (deck thinning) OR creates confetti barriers blocking corruption.

42. The Passive-Aggressive UI

As Moral Injury rises, the UI becomes petty. The clock-out button tooltip: "Are you sure? You seem to be enjoying this." Save confirmation: "Progress saved. Not that it matters." Daily Memo greeting degrades: "Dear Valued Employee" to "Dear Employee" to "Dear" to "...". Loading tips shift from helpful to sardonic to existential. The final loading tip — just "Tip:" with nothing after it — is funnier and more disturbing than any written joke.

PART VIII: NARRATIVE ARCHITECTURE

43. The Great Audit (Narrative Structure)

The narrative is a conspiracy uncovered across multiple runs. The ultimate goal is The Great Audit — a final, 15-minute interrogation that determines the fate of the Investigator and the Agency. Progress is measured by Milestones:

Milestone	Trigger	Unlock
The First Promotion	5 successful shifts	Internal Audit meta-hub, first Colleague via Rumor Mill
The Redacted Truth	10 Corrupted Files analysed	Whistleblower Memo hinting at Agency's true purpose
The Breach	First Fugue State survived	Revelation: Clients are former employees
The Great Audit	Conspiracy Board completed	Final 15-minute interrogation against the Agency

44. Procedural Storytelling: The Paper Trail

The story is told through the tools the player uses. Early Game memos: "Loud Chewing" and "Missing Staplers." Mid Game: "Unexplained Screams in Sector 4" and "Mandatory Memory Wipes." Late Game: memos from "The Director" (who may not be human) addressing the player by name (meta-narrative). Each client reveals a fragment of a secret code. Connected fragments on the Conspiracy Board unlock the path to The Great Audit.

45. The Endings: Clocking Out

Ending	Path	Result
A: The Company Man	High Moral Injury: frame aliens, sign NDAs, promote efficiency	Final shot: your hands become the rotting, seaweed-covered
B: The Whistleblower	Low Moral Injury: show Mercy, refuse unethical demands, fire real Boss	Breaks office reality. Shatters, revealing mundane 1920s street. Wall
C: The Great Audit	Find Old Data in redacted files (Inscription-style meta-secrets)	15-minute interrogation vs the Agency. Success: delete Repeat Offender

46. Four-Layer Meta-Narrative

Layer 1: The desk simulator. Process anomalous claims. Dark comedy, absurd bureaucracy. **Layer 2:** The Internal Audit reveals the company knows about anomalies and is deliberately mishandling them. Cover-up. **Layer 3:** Found media. Audio logs, corrupted video, memos from previous Desk 42 employees who tried to expose the truth and were "reassigned." **Layer 4:** ARG elements. Steganographic data in redaction patterns. Fake corporate website accessible via in-game URL. Community-driven seasonal decoding events.

47. The Complicit Narrator

The AI Storyteller "The Tide" is an unreliable narrator using corporate-speak that minimises horror. As soul integrity decreases, narration becomes more honest. At zero, narration becomes pure doublespeak the player cannot parse — language itself becomes an obstacle. The Tide occasionally lies — describing a claim as routine when it is anomalous — testing whether the player trusts their observations or the narrator.

48. Procedural Moral Dilemmas

Dilemmas generated from intersecting systems, not scripted. When a Repeat Offender returns with a legitimate claim. When faction demands conflict. When a coworker asks you to falsify a claim. The game never labels choices as good or evil — it presents consequences. Moral weight emerges from mechanical cost.

49. The Shift Report (Hub Dialogue System)

After each shift, coworkers comment on specific events from the previous shift: which claims you processed, which moral compromises you made, which archetype you played. Characters reference your build, faction standings, and soul integrity. Over 70+ shifts, new dialogue continues appearing. The system tracks 30+ variables for context-appropriate dialogue.

PART IX: AUDIO DESIGN

50. Procedural Corporate Jazz

Every bureaucratic action generates musical elements from office-sound samples. Typing produces hi-hat patterns, stamping triggers snare hits, phone slams create cymbal crashes, shredding produces sustained cymbal wash, filing cabinets add bass thumps. Intensity scales with workload: calm desk produces ambient muzak, crisis-level queue generates frantic free jazz. The player's efficiency creates the groove. This is not a rhythm game — the natural workflow rhythm becomes musical.

51. The Approaching Audit (Spatial Audio Threats)

The supervisor's footsteps are spatially positioned in binaural audio. Measured steps = routine check, rapid steps = angry, shuffling = drunk (late-shift event). No visual indicator — audio is the only warning. Printer jams audible through the ceiling indicate system cascades. Whispered conversations behind the break room door reveal faction gossip. Fluorescent light frequency changes indicate anomalous proximity.

52. Acoustic Signatures

Each office area has a distinct acoustic signature. Cubicle: dry and tight. Break room: cafeteria reverb. Supply closet: claustrophobic. Boardroom: cavernous. If visuals were disabled, players should know where they are by sound alone. When anomalous events distort reality, acoustic signatures shift — the cubicle suddenly sounds like a cathedral, signalling dimensional breach.

53. The Stress Crescendo

Soul integrity drives the entire audio environment. 100%: ASMR-adjacent office sounds. 75%: fluorescent hum, louder clock. 50%: audible breathing, heartbeat underlay, hostile voices. 25%: tinnitus, distorted speech, atonal jazz. 0%: total silence except slow breathing — the most disturbing state, signalling complete dissociation.

PART X: REPLAYABILITY & ENGAGEMENT

54. The Performance Review (Completion Matrix)

11 archetypes x 8 Compliance Vow tiers = 88 unique victory conditions, each tracked in the Performance Review screen. Completing a tier with a specific archetype earns a commemorative desk ornament (cosmetic). Completing a vow tier with a specific office supply earns a supply sticker — 50+ supplies x 8 tiers = 400+ sticker possibilities.

55. Shift Badges (Micro-Achievements)

Every run generates contextual badges: "Denied a Claim from an Elder God," "Processed 50 Forms Without Error," "Maintained 100% Soul Integrity," "Filed a Grievance Against Your Own Department." Badges appear in run history and on the employee ID card. Some are extremely rare, requiring specific unlikely event combinations.

56. Seeded Runs Architecture

The seed controls seven variables that produce fundamentally different experiences:

Variable	Impact on Run
Claim Queue Composition	Starting states, counter-traits, hidden data, classification tags per client
Office Supply Shop Inventory	Which relics available and when — front-loading specific supplies enables different builds
Punch Card Draft Pool	Which cards appear at each selection — early REDACT favours Gaslighter, early EXPEDITE favours B
Rumor Mill Event Sequence	Which cascades trigger and when — calm mid-game vs chaotic from shift one
Office Temperature Cycle	Duration of PEAK, LUNCH, CRASH phases — survival vs optimisation seeds
Faction Starting Dispositions	Which departments start friendly/neutral/hostile — hostile Legal = dangerous LITIGIOUS clients
Regulation Escalation Order	Which verification requirements appear on which days — front-loaded vs back-loaded difficulty

57. Dark Humour as Systemic Output

Dark humour is not written — it is generated by systems. Three engines produce comedy:

The Passive-Aggressive UI: Tooltips, save confirmations, loading tips, and memo greetings degrade with Moral Injury. The UI becomes petty, sardonic, then existentially empty.

Procedural Claim Content: Claims generated by combining mundane form fields with anomalous content. "CLAIM TYPE: Workers' Compensation. INCIDENT: Spontaneous tentacle manifestation during quarterly review. WITNESS: The photocopier (disputed)." The bureaucratic framing IS the joke.

The Rumor Mill Comedy Engine: Memos generated from game state. Player behaviour produces contextually appropriate corporate absurdism. Players are incentivised to experiment just to see the system's reaction.

58. The Retirement Fund (Cosmetic Progression)

Secondary currency from achievements and high-tier Vow victories. Spent on desk themes (wood grain, brutalist concrete, eldritch), monitor wallpapers, coffee mug skins, custom stamp designs, desk plant species (grow across runs, can die if neglected), and office chair upgrades. No gameplay impact — pure self-expression.

59. Modding Support & Community Tools

Exposed tools: Punch Card Creator (custom card effects), Claim Template Editor (custom anomalous cases), Challenge Audit Designer (expanded Custom Audits), Sound Pack System (custom office sounds for procedural jazz). Steam Workshop integration for discoverability.

PART XI: REFERENCE GAMES & DESIGN DNA

60. Reference Game Mapping

Reference	What It Contributes	Desk 42 System
Baba Is You	Rules as mutable objects at runtime	Red Tape Engine (punch-card behaviour injection)
FTL / IXION	Ship-as-body resource management, UI decay	Caffeine/Protocol dials, desk deterioration
Against the Storm	Impatience timer, competing stakeholder needs	Unpaid Overtime clock, Departmental Factions
Look Outside	Penalising the player for looking at threats	Don't Look Up zone
Dark Queen of Mortholme	Procedural counter-trait generation	Repeat Offender Database
Disco Elysium	UI elements as sub-personalities, internal dialogue	Internal Audit meta-hub
Hades / Balatro	Variable ratio synergies, milestone progression	Office Supplies, Compliance Vows, scoring cascade
Inscription	Physical desk constraints, meta-secrets, layered reality	Desk as in-gameplay surface, Old Data, four-layer narrative
Papers Please	Moral weight through mechanical cost, escalating regulations	Moral ledger, verification complexity
Luck Be a Landlord	Spatial adjacency synergies	Claim Queue Grid
Vampire Survivors	Equipment evolution, compressed sessions	Office Supply Evolution, Hurry Mode
Monster Train	Multi-floor positioning, async multiplayer	Desk Layout Zones, Hell Rush
Ape Out	Procedural percussion from player actions	Procedural Corporate Jazz
Hellblade	Binaural audio as HUD replacement	Spatial audio threat detection
Severance / Control	Mid-century brutalist architecture as psychological environment	Cybernetic, environmental design
TVA (Loki) / MIB	Retro-futuristic analog technology, deadpan technology	Technology design, tonal identity
Rocko's Modern Life	Crooked environmental personality, corporate satire	Environmental distortion, sardonic world behaviour

PART XII: DEVELOPMENT ROADMAP

61. Ship Tier / Update Tier / Expansion Tier

61.1 Ship Tier — Minimum Viable Roguelite

The 9-to-5 core campaign. 4 archetypes (Auditor, Gaslighter, Bureaucrat, IT Person). Office Supply synergy system. Repeat Offender Database. Moral Injury system with passive-aggressive UI. Internal Audit meta-hub with Employee Handbook. Unpaid Overtime death state. One ending path (The Whistleblower). Binaural Corporate Stress audio. Procedural claim generation with dark humour. Post-it Memory System and basic Conspiracy Board. The Tide AI Storyteller. Seeded runs with shareable codes.

61.2 Update Tier — First Major Content Patch

Compliance Vows difficulty system (6 vows, 3 ranks each). 3 additional archetypes (Whistleblower, HR Rep, Intern). The Daily Brief mode with leaderboards. Scoring Cascade system. Remaining endings (The Company Man, The Great Audit). Departmental Factions. Escalating Regulations. Cross-Claim Deduction. CorpOS desktop simulation. The Reflection mechanic.

61.3 Expansion Tier — Long-Tail Engagement

Branch Office Transfer adventures (4 departments). Hell Rush async multiplayer. Custom Audits with community leaderboards. Full 11-archetype roster (Middle Manager, Consultant, Union Rep, Archivist). Office Supply Evolution system. Claim Queue Grid spatial adjacency. Stand Up From the Desk exploration. Four-Layer Meta-Narrative (Layers 3-4). Procedural Corporate Jazz audio system. Acoustic Signatures. Modding tools and Steam Workshop. The Retirement Fund cosmetic progression. ARG elements.

END OF DOCUMENT

"Every run provides a new piece of the puzzle, making the player feel like they are slowly outsmarting a system that was designed to crush them. This sense of intellectual progression is what drives the player to clock in for just one more shift."

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